Radiotherapy for stomach cancer

Radiotherapy uses high-energy rays to destroy stomach cancer cells.

On this page

- What is radiotherapy?
- When radiotherapy is used for stomach cancer
- Having radiotherapy treatment
- Side effects of radiotherapy for stomach cancer
- How we can help

What is radiotherapy?

Radiotherapy uses high-energy rays called radiation to treat cancer. It destroys cancer cells in the area where the radiotherapy is given.

Some normal cells in the area can also be damaged by radiotherapy. This can cause side effects. As the normal cells recover, the side effects usually get better.

When radiotherapy is used for stomach cancer

Radiotherapy for stomach cancer may be given:

- to help symptoms, such as bleeding from the stomach – this is called palliative radiotherapy
- as extra treatment to prevent cancer from coming back.

Radiotherapy is always carefully planned by a team of experts. They will plan your treatment so it does as little harm as possible to normal cells.

We have more information about radiotherapy.

Booklets and resources

Booklets

01 Aug 2022

Radiotherapy - easy read

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/radiotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 12 October 2026

Having radiotherapy treatment

You will have a hospital appointment to plan your treatment.

Radiotherapy is normally given as a number of short, daily treatments in a hospital radiotherapy department.

You usually have radiotherapy as an outpatient. You sometimes have it during a hospital stay. Usually, each appointment takes about 10 to 30 minutes. Your radiotherapy team will explain how many treatments you will have and when you will have them. Your course of treatment may last up to a few weeks.

The person who operates the machine is called a radiographer. They give you information and support during your treatment.

We have more information about having having external beam radiotherapy.

Support from Macmillan

Macmillan is here to support you. If you would like to talk, you can:

- Call the Macmillan Support Line for free on 0808 808 00 00.
- Chat to our specialists online.
- Visit our stomach cancer forum to talk with people who have been affected by stomach cancer, share your experience, and ask an expert your questions.

Side effects of radiotherapy for stomach cancer

Radiotherapy can cause side effects in the area of your body that is being treated. You may also have some general side effects, such as feeling tired. Sometimes side effects get worse for a time during and after you have finished radiotherapy before they get better.

Your cancer doctor, specialist nurse or radiographer will tell you what to expect. They will give you advice on what you can do to manage side effects. If you have any new side effects or if side effects get worse, tell them straight away.

Tiredness

Radiotherapy often makes people feel tired. Tiredness (fatigue) may get worse as treatment goes on. If you are having radiotherapy alongside other treatments, such as surgery or chemotherapy, you may feel more tired. But there are things you can do to help, such as:

- get plenty of rest
- do some gentle exercise, such as short walks
- eat a healthy diet and drink plenty of fluids
- ask others for help with everyday jobs, if you have friends or family members who can support you.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/radiotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 12 October 2026

After treatment finishes, you may continue to feel tired for weeks or months. If it does not get better, tell your cancer doctor or specialist nurse.

We have more information about coping with tiredness (fatigue).

Skin reactions

The skin in the area that is treated may:

- redden
- darken
- feel sore or itchy.

Your radiographer or specialist nurse will give you advice on taking care of your skin. If your skin becomes sore or itchy or changes colour, tell them straight away. They can give you advice and treatments if needed.

Skin reactions should get better within 4 to 6 weeks of treatment finishing.

During your treatment, you are usually advised to:

- wear loose-fitting clothes made from natural fibres, such as cotton
- wash your skin gently with soap and water and gently pat it dry
- avoid rubbing the skin
- avoid very hot things – for example, heat pads
- avoid cooling pads but these may be helpful in some situations so speak to your team about using these first
- avoid wet shaving
- avoid hair-removing creams or products, including wax and laser treatment
- follow your radiotherapy team's advice about using moisturisers and deodorants
- protect the treated area from the sun.

Loss of appetite

During radiotherapy, you may not feel like eating very much. But it is important to try to maintain your weight. Your dietitian can give you advice on ways to build up your diet and maintain or gain weight.

Feeling sick

Radiotherapy and chemotherapy can cause you to feel sick (nausea) and be sick (vomit). This can usually be treated with anti-sickness drugs (anti-emetics). Your cancer doctor can give you these.

Indigestion

Radiotherapy to the stomach can cause indigestion. If you have this, let your radiographer or specialist nurse know. They may be able to give you medicines to help.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/radiotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 12 October 2026

Tummy pain

This should get better after treatment. Your cancer doctor can give you painkillers to help.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References

Below is a sample of the sources used in our stomach cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

Lordick F, Carneiro S, Cascinu T, Fleitas K, Haustermans G, Piessen A, et al. Gastric cancer: ESMO Clinical Practice Guideline for diagnosis, treatment and follow-up. Annals of Oncology. 2022;33(10): 1005–1020. Available from www.doi.org/10.1016/j.annonc.2022.07.004 [accessed July 2023].

National Institute for Care and Health Excellence. Oesophago-gastric cancer: assessment and management in adults NICE guideline [NG83]. 2018. Available from www.nice.org.uk/guidance/ng83 [accessed July 2023].

Cancer Information Development team

Author

Dr Chris Jones

Reviewer

Speciality Registrar in Clinical Oncologist and Clinical Lecturer in Clinical Oncology

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 November 2024 | Next review: 01 November 2027

Our cancer information meets the PIF TICK quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about how we produce our information.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/radiotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 12 October 2026

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as ‘you’ so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms ‘men’ and ‘women’ or ‘male’ and ‘female’. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information here.

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.

Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.

Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don’t want to call.

Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.

Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/radiotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 12 October 2026

Get help

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/radiotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 12 October 2026